12 –16 October 2026

The brief in 30 seconds

The challenge
Turn the existing Education Starts Early into a strong, recognizable and engaging global communication campaign.

The opportunity
Use the 2026 Global Report on Early Childhood Care and Education (ECCE) and its high-level launch on 19–20 November 2026 as an optional opportunity to amplify the campaign, while developing a concept that can stand on its own and extend well beyond the launch.

The core message
Education starts early. And investment in education needs to start early too.

The audience
Focus exclusively on the general public, particularly young adults. Make the message simple, engaging and relevant to people who may have never heard of ECCE.

Your task
Make people see education differently. Do not simply advertise a report. Build a campaign around an idea.

The creative challenge will focus on six core deliverables developed over three days, prioritizing the strength of the concept and its creative expression rather than fully produced campaign materials.

Background and context

UNESCO is the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization. It works to build peace through international cooperation in education, science, culture and communication. Education is at the heart of UNESCO's mandate. UNESCO supports countries in strengthening education systems and advancing the right to inclusive and equitable quality education and lifelong learning opportunities.

One of UNESCO's key areas of work is Early Childhood Care and Education (ECCE), which covers children from birth to age eight, including the stages of 0–3, 3–6 and 6–8 years. Early childhood is a critical period for children's learning, development and well-being. Yet progress towards Sustainable Development Goal Target 4.2 remains insufficient. Early childhood continues to face persistent underinvestment, fragmented governance and important data gaps that affect planning and resource allocation.

Against this background, UNESCO is seeking to strengthen its public communication around early childhood through the Education Starts Early campaign. The ambition is to make this existing campaign more visible, engaging and recognizable, and to develop it into a broader communication platform capable of living across different formats, audiences, events and countries. The campaign is closely connected to the 2026 Global Report on Early Childhood Care and Education, jointly developed by UNESCO, UNICEF and OECD, and to its high-level launch at UNESCO Headquarters in Paris on 19–20

November 2026. The Report focuses on financing for equitable and inclusive access to quality ECCE and provides evidence, practical financing pathways and policy options to support countries in moving from commitments to implementation.

The launch will bring together Member States, partners, experts, local authorities, youth, civil society and other stakeholders to discuss practical solutions, strengthen political commitment and build momentum towards future global action on ECCE.

Education Starts Early is an existing UNESCO campaign promoting the message that learning begins well before primary school. For this Battle, students are invited to build on the campaign, strengthen its creative expression and explore how it can become more recognizable, engaging and adaptable across different formats and audiences. The 2026 Global Report on ECCE and its launch should be considered as sources of inspiration and contextual opportunities rather than mandatory elements around which the campaign must be built. The priority is to create a compelling public-awareness concept about the importance of early childhood education.

About early childhood care and education

Early Childhood Care and Education goes beyond preparation for primary school. Children begin learning from their earliest years through play, language, movement, relationships, interaction, care and discovery. Education therefore does not begin on the first day of primary school.

This idea is at the heart of the campaign: Education starts early. The campaign aims to help wider audiences understand that strong early childhood experiences matter for learning, skills, development and well-being throughout life. It also seeks to make a second connection clear:
If education starts early, investment needs to start early too.

Quality early childhood opportunities require trained professionals, supportive environments, accessible services, coordinated policies and sustainable financing.

About the Education Starts Early campaign

Education Starts Early is the main campaign platform. It should not be understood only as a slogan linked to the November launch.

The ambition is to develop it into a broader and more recognizable communication campaign that can grow over time and be used across different formats, platforms and countries.
The campaign should help make early childhood more visible within the broader public understanding of education.

When people think about education, they often picture a school, classroom, teacher, desk or diploma. The campaign should challenge this assumption and make people understand that learning begins much earlier.

For the purposes of this Battle, students should concentrate on developing a single powerful creative concept that can be expressed through visual communication, short-form video, social media and participatory experiences.

The objective is not to design a complete institutional communication strategy, but to demonstrate the potential of an original, coherent and internationally adaptable campaign idea.

Connection with the 2026 Global Report on ECCE

The 2026 Global Report on ECCE provides an important evidence base for the campaign.
The Report focuses on one of the most pressing challenges facing early childhood systems: how to finance inclusive, equitable and quality ECCE at scale.

It seeks to support countries with evidence, policy options and practical pathways for moving from commitments to implementation. It also highlights the importance of reaching children who are most at risk of being left behind, strengthening the workforce, improving quality and building stronger systems.

Students can therefore use the Report and its Executive Summary and Key Messages as substantive references. However, the assignment is not to advertise the Report itself. The use of specific findings, statistics or references to the November launch is optional. Students are encouraged to draw inspiration from the Report where relevant, without being required to develop dedicated Report communication products.

The challenge is to translate the importance of early childhood education into communication that is understandable, human, visual, emotionally engaging, memorable and suitable for non-specialist audiences.

The problem statement

The problem to solve:

How can UNESCO turn Education Starts Early into a strong, recognizable and engaging campaign that helps people understand that education begins long before primary school and makes the case for investing in early childhood?

The campaign should make people understand that learning begins long before primary school and that investing in the early years is therefore an essential part of investing in education.
Students should focus on the human and emotional dimension of this message, finding creative ways to make early learning meaningful and relevant to young adults and the wider public. Technical themes such as financing, access, equity and quality may inform the concept but should not dominate its expression.

The desired reaction is something close to:
“Of course education starts early. Why have I never thought about it that way?”

The campaign should create a connection between:
early learning → strong beginnings → quality opportunities → investment and action.
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Campaign objectives

The communication campaign should aim to:

- Increase public awareness that education begins in the earliest years.
- Make ECCE easier to understand for non-specialist audiences.
- Strengthen recognition of Education Starts Early as a campaign.

- Connect early childhood to broader education, social and development priorities.
- Communicate the importance of investing in quality ECCE.
- Engage the general public, particularly young adults, through compelling, creative and accessible communication.
- Encourage curiosity, emotional connection and public participation around the importance of early learning.
- Develop a recognizable creative concept that can be adapted to different formats and international contexts.
- Demonstrate the campaign's potential to live beyond the November launch without requiring a comprehensive implementation or institutional communication strategy.

Target audiences

For this creative exercise, the campaign should focus on one primary audience: the general public, with particular attention to young adults.

This includes students, young professionals and other individuals who may not have children or direct experience with early childhood education.

The message should be understandable without prior knowledge of education policy. The challenge is to create a compelling public-facing campaign that can resonate across backgrounds and generations, with particular relevance for young adults.

Key messages

The Executive Summary and Key Messages of the 2026 Global Report on ECCE should serve as a substantive reference for the students' work.
Students are not expected to reproduce the content of the Executive Summary.
Instead, they should use it to identify the strongest messages for wider audiences and evidence that could support their ideas.

The creative proposal should prioritize one clear central message rather than attempting to communicate multiple findings or recommendations.

Possible supporting messages include:

- Education begins long before the first day of school.
- Young children learn through play, care, relationships and everyday experiences.
- Early learning lays important foundations for future development and well-being.
- Every child deserves access to quality early learning opportunities.
- Investing in education means investing from the earliest years.

Creative expectations

Students are expected to develop one coherent creative campaign concept. The concept should be built around a strong idea that can generate different formats and executions.

Students should consider:

- What is the central creative idea?
- What is the human insight behind it?
- What is the main visual expression?

- What should people remember?
- What would make someone stop and pay attention?
- What can people participate in or share?
- How can the same idea be expressed consistently through a visual, a short video, social media content and a participatory activation?
- How can the concept work in another cultural or linguistic context?

The strongest ideas should be simple enough to understand quickly but rich enough to support a broader campaign.

The big visual

A key part of the Battle will be to propose one strong visual concept capable of conveying the Education Starts Early message almost immediately. This visual should have the potential to become a recognizable campaign asset. **Students should propose one main Key Visual or campaign poster that captures the central idea. The execution may be presented as a designed visual or sufficiently developed mock-up.**

Communication products to develop

In light of the three-day creative challenge, the expected deliverables have been consolidated into six essential elements. Each team should demonstrate how one central concept can be translated into a small, coherent set of creative proposals.

1. Big Concept & Insight
A clear articulation of the central creative idea and the human insight that inspires it.
Expected output:

- One sentence summarizing the Big Concept.
- One concise explanation of the underlying insight.

2. Key Visual / Poster
One strong hero visual or campaign poster expressing the central idea behind Education Starts Early.
The visual should:

- Communicate the idea within seconds.
- Capture attention.
- Have a distinctive creative identity.
- Have the potential to extend to other campaign formats.

One principal visual is expected. A complete series of campaign posters or a comprehensive visual identity system is not required.

3. Video Pitch (15–30 seconds)
A creative proposal for a short video lasting approximately 15–30 seconds.
Students may present the idea through:

- A short script.
- A storyboard.
- A visual treatment.
- A simple animatic or prototype.

The objective is to communicate the narrative and creative potential of the video. A fully produced video is not required.

4. Social Media Communication
Illustrative social media adaptations of the main campaign concept.
Possible formats include:

- Static posts.
- Carousels.
- Stories.
- Reels or vertical video concepts.
- Animated or short-form content.

Teams should present a small selection of examples showing how the same creative idea can work consistently across social media. A full content calendar or comprehensive social media strategy is not expected.

5. Participatory Activation
One creative idea for encouraging public engagement and participation, either online or in a physical space.
Possible approaches include:

- A public installation.
- An interactive street or university activation.
- A social media challenge.
- A question or participatory storytelling format.
- An invitation to share personal experiences or memories of early learning.

6. International Adaptation
One illustrative example demonstrates how the campaign concept could be adapted to a different linguistic or cultural context.
The example should show how the creative idea remains recognizable while being relevant to another audience.

Students may choose the country, language or cultural context they wish to illustrate. A comprehensive international deployment strategy is not required. However, diversity and cultural inclusivity should be reflected in the proposed creative approach.

Note: Visual identity and brand requirements
The campaign will sit under the UNESCO brand.The UNESCO Visual Identity Guidelines and the Education Starts Early visual identity are attached and should be treated as mandatory references.
All proposed communication should respect applicable guidance relating to UNESCO logo use, positioning, typography, colour, photography, accessibility and digital applications.

Students are encouraged to explore how the existing campaign's creative expression can be strengthened and extended through visual devices, typographic treatments, illustration, photography and digital formats. The final proposal should remain clearly connected to UNESCO and should not create the impression of an independent or unrelated brand.

Tone of voice

The campaign should be:

- **Human**: People and experiences should come before institutional language.
- **Simple**: The message should be understandable without knowing what ECCE means.
- **Intelligent**: Simple should not mean simplistic.
- **Optimistic**: The campaign should focus on possibilities and positive change.

- **Urgent**: The early years cannot be postponed.
- **Bold**:T he communication needs to be visible and memorable.
- **Inclusive**: The campaign should reflect different children, families, contexts and realities.
- **Credible**: The communication should remain grounded in evidence.
- **Emotional**: People should feel something.
- **Unexpected**: Avoid overly predictable institutional communication.

Diversity should be represented throughtut the compaign

What to avoid

Students should avoid:

- Overly institutional communication.
- Heavy or technical messages.
- Generic imagery of smiling children with no clear creative idea.
- Pity-based narratives.
- Overly deterministic messages suggesting that early childhood alone determines a person's entire future.
- Concepts that work only once.
- Ideas that depend exclusively on very large budgets.
- Unauthorized redesign of UNESCO's visual identity.
- Concepts that cannot reasonably be adapted across countries or cultures.

Think globally

UNESCO works internationally. The campaign should therefore have the potential to work across different cultures, languages and contexts.

Students should ask: Could this concept work in Paris, Dakar, Bogotá, Bangkok or Seoul?
The execution may change from one context to another, but the main idea should remain recognizable.
Concepts should avoid depending entirely on English-language wordplay, one national context, assumptions specific to one culture, or expensive technology that limits adaptability.
For this Battle, one concrete example of international adaptation is sufficient to demonstrate the concept's global potential.

Campaign journey

Students are encouraged to think about the long-term potential of their campaign idea, but are not expected to develop a detailed communication roadmap.
The November launch of the 2026 Global Report on ECCE can provide a relevant opportunity to amplify selected campaign ideas.
However, it is not necessary to structure proposals around the launch. The strongest concepts should be able to reach audiences independently of any particular event and remain relevant over time.

Expected deliverables

Each team should present one coherent creative campaign proposal consisting of six core elements:

No.	Deliverable	Expected output
1	Big Concept & Insight	One-sentence concept and concise explanation of the human insight
2	Key Visual / Poster	One strong hero image or campaign poster
3	Video Pitch	15–30-second concept, script or storyboard
4	Social Media Communication	A small selection of illustrative posts, carousels or vertical formats
5	Participatory Activation	One creative engagement idea, online or in a public space
6	International Adaptation	One example adapted to a different language or cultural context

The six elements should feel like different expressions of the same central creative idea, rather than six unrelated proposals.

Final production-ready assets are not required. Students may present concepts, mock-ups, storyboards and illustrative prototypes.

Evaluation criteria

Proposals will be assessed according to:

- strength of the creative idea;
- clarity and simplicity;
- emotional impact;
- relevance to ECCE;
- use of the Global Report's messages;
- creativity and originality;
- campaign potential;
- quality of the visual approach;
- participation potential;
- global adaptability;
- coherence with UNESCO and Education Starts Early visual identities;
- feasibility;
- potential for long-term use.

Particular attention will be given to the strength of the central creative concept, its resonance with young adults and the consistency of its expression across the six deliverables.

Teams will not be expected to demonstrate institutional communication strategies or fully developed production outputs.

Final presentation

Finalist teams will present their recommendations on **Friday, 16 October 2026**.
The recommended format is approximately: **20 minute presentation + 10-minute Q&A**

Presentations should prioritize the central creative concept and the six expected deliverables. Additional explorations may be included only if time permits.

Reference materials provided

The following materials are provided to students alongside this brief:

- Executive Summary and Key Messages
- Concept Note
- Provisional Agenda
- UNESCO Visual Identity Guidelines
- Education Starts Early visual identity
- UNESCO – Early childhood care and education
  Main thematic webpage bringing together UNESCO's work, publications, initiatives and resources on ECCE. Early childhood care and education – UNESCO
- What you need to know about early childhood care and education
  A useful overview of why ECCE matters, the global situation, financing challenges and UNESCO's approach. What you need to know about ECCE – UNESCO
- The right to a strong foundation – Global Report on Early Childhood Care and Education 2024
  The first Global Report on ECCE, jointly published by UNESCO and UNICEF, providing useful background on global and regional ECCE trends and the evidence underpinning the global agenda. The right to a strong foundation – UNESCO
- Global Partnership Strategy for early childhood 2021–2030
  Provides additional background on global cooperation and the wider policy framework around early childhood care, education and development. Global Partnership Strategy for early childhood – UNESCO
- UNESCO Member States commit to invest at least 10% of education budgets in early childhood education
  Useful background on financing commitments emerging from the 2022 World Conference on ECCE and the Tashkent Declaration. Investing in early childhood education – UNESCO